

You are the boat keeper.

Start here. Read page 2 to take a trip. Pages 3 and 4 help with examples and special cards.

You are **Charon**. Souls are waiting by the river. Choose who gets in your boat and where to take them.

Your goal: finish **6 trips** and pay both ferry bills. Help as many souls as you can along the way. You do not have to carry everyone to win.

Five words to know

Crossing: one boat trip.

Obols: your coins.

Standing: points you spend on memories and river pressure.

Pressure: how hard the trip is.

Memory: a card left by a soul you delivered. Also called **residue**.

Set up the game

Start with **2 coins**, **3 Standing** and a boat with **4 seats**. Set the trip marker to **1**. Put souls **S01 to S05** on the shore. Keep S06 to S12 in order as the supply. Do not shuffle.

Start with no wraiths and no memories in any pile. Each soul starts with **0 refusal marks**. You may look at every card, even one still in the supply. One friend can help move cards and count points.

Choose one place for the whole boat

Place	Pay before leaving	River pressure
Elysium	1 coin	0
Asphodel	0 coins	1
Tartarus	0 coins	2. Earn 1 extra coin if at least one soul arrives.

Any soul may visit any of these places in this prototype. Events and upgrades are off. You cannot trade coins for Standing.

Take one trip.

Follow these steps in order. The digital demo does the counting and card-moving for you.

- 1 **Fill the shore.** Keep waiting souls and their marks. Add the next souls from the supply until 5 are waiting. If the supply is empty, add none.
- 2 **Draw memories.** Take up to 2 from the front of the memory line. There are none on the first trip. Page 4 explains the piles.
- 3 **Choose, then pay.** Pick passengers using **4 seats or fewer**, one place, and optionally one memory. Read the cards. Pay the route cost and **1 Standing** if you use a memory. Choose its target now if needed. You must already have the points to pay.
- 4 **Check the river.** Add route pressure, **1 for each wraith**, and any soldier conflict. Subtract protection. The answer cannot go below 0. Spend that much Standing. **Not enough? The game ends before arrival.** Exactly enough is okay.
- 5 **Arrive and collect.** Gain each passenger's printed coins and Standing. Add the Tartarus bonus if earned. Each delivered soul leaves one memory. Put new memories at the back of the line, lowest soul ID first. You cannot use them on this trip.
- 6 **Pay the bill.** After arrival on trips **3 and 6**, pay **3 coins**. This bill is called a quota. Arrival coins can pay it. **Not enough? The game ends here.**
- 7 **Mark who waited.** Each soul still on shore gains **1 refusal mark**, unless a memory prevents it. A separated partner may gain 1 extra mark; see page 3. At **3 marks**, move the soul to the wraith area.
- 8 **Clear the boat.** Keep delivered souls aside with their destinations. Discard the played memory first, then the rest of your hand from left to right. After trip 6, you win if the game has not ended early. Otherwise, move to the next trip.

Before you leave: change your plan as much as you like. After you confirm, your choices are locked.

Empty boats are allowed. Costs, pressure, bills and waiting marks still apply. An empty Tartarus boat earns no bonus coin.

Try the first trip.

This is one example, not the only good choice. Start with 2 coins and 3 Standing.

- 1 **Board Mother, Child and Poet.** Mother needs 2 seats. Child needs 1. Poet needs 1. **2 + 1 + 1 = 4 seats.**
- 2 **Choose Asphodel.** It costs no coins. Its pressure is 1. Poet gives 1 protection because two other souls are aboard. **1 - 1 = 0 pressure.** Spend no Standing.
- 3 **Collect the rewards.** These three souls pay no coins, but each gives 1 Standing. You now have **2 coins and 6 Standing.** Mother and Child each leave a Joined Memory. Poet leaves Recollection.
- 4 **Finish the trip.** There is no bill yet. Merchant and Red Soldier each gain 1 refusal mark. Put the new memories in S01, S02, S05 order. Next trip, add Blue Soldier, Cook and Mason. Draw the two Joined Memories.

Partners want to travel together

The linked pairs are **Mother + Child** and **Musician + Listener**. If a pair arrives together, **each** leaves a Joined Memory. If one arrives without the other, that soul leaves a Faint Memory.

If **both partners were waiting on the shore** and only one boards, the one left behind gains **1 extra refusal mark.**

Usually that means **1 normal + 1 extra = 2 marks.** A memory that stops the normal mark does **not** stop the extra mark.

No extra separation mark happens if the partner is still in the supply, already delivered, or already a wraith. Bringing the other partner later does not upgrade an old memory.

Three special passenger rules

Red + Blue Soldier: if both board, add 1 pressure total.

Poet: gives 1 protection with at least two other souls aboard.

Keeper: gives 1 protection only when travelling alone.

A wraith starts adding pressure on the next trip. It stays in the wraith area and cannot board or give rewards.

Memory cheat sheet

Optional help for players and the friend running the paper game.

Use at most 1 memory per trip. Every memory costs **1 Standing** before the river check. You may choose to use none. Protection lowers pressure; it does not give Standing back.

Memory	What it does
R01 / Steadiness	Gives 2 protection.
R02 / Vigil	Gives 3 protection if at least one passenger needs 2 seats. Otherwise, gives 0.
R03 / Recollection	Choose one soul staying on shore. Stop its normal refusal mark this trip.
R04 / Accord	Stops the Red and Blue Soldiers' extra pressure, if present. Also gives 1 protection.
R05 / Joined Memory	Gives 2 protection. Also choose one waiting soul and stop its normal refusal mark this trip.
R06 / Faint Memory	Gives 1 protection.

For R03 and R05: choose a waiting soul if there is one. If nobody is waiting, you may still play the memory, but its waiting-soul help does nothing. It cannot help an existing wraith. Extra separation marks still happen.

Keep the memory piles in order

Draw line: take from the front; add new memories at the back.

Hand: the cards you drew for this trip. You cannot save them in your hand for next time.

Discard: keep used and unused hand cards here in order. When the draw line runs out, turn the discard into a new line with the oldest discarded card first. Never shuffle.

Draw until you have 2 cards, or until no cards are left to draw. Each memory keeps the ID of the soul that left it. Different souls can leave separate copies of the same memory.

Quick reminder: fill shore, draw, choose and pay, cross, collect, pay any bill, mark waiting souls, clean up.

If the game ends early, stop immediately. Do not finish the later steps.

Rules source: The_Ferryman_Design_Workbook.md v0.2, sections 5-10 (17 Sep 2026); digital engine.js (18 Sep 2026). This guide explains those rules without changing them.